

The gender regime of Swedish banks[☆]

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Abstract

Organizations have “gender regimes”, internal structures, processes and beliefs that distribute women and men into different tasks and positions. The case of a planned change in Swedish banks demonstrates how different local gender regimes affect the change process and how this process, in turn, affects women and men in diverse ways.

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1. Introduction

Swedish banks, like banks everywhere, employ women and men in different capacities and at different levels of the organizational hierarchy. Banking, in terms of number of employees, is a female domain, but in terms of power and control, it is firmly in the hands of men. This remains true even though banking, in Sweden and other industrial countries, has provided opportunities for some women to move into higher level jobs (Bird, 1990). The mass of women working for banks are in low-status and relatively low-paid jobs. A wage gap between women and men also exists in the banking sector. Thus, banks are gendered organizations in the most obvious sense: wages, tasks and hierarchical positions are all distributed differently to women and men.

While banks everywhere have some sort of gender organization, these patterns are not always the same; history and local customs produce variation. The term “gender regime” was originated by Connell (1987) to refer to the patterning of gender processes in particular social units at particular historical times. The gender regime of Swedish banks

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differs from the gender regime of US banks; the gender regime of the 1940s differs from that of the 1980s.

Studies of women in banking in the US have tried to explain the creation and recreation of sex segregation (Strober & Arnold, 1987) or to account for the feminization of banking (Bird, 1990). In this paper, I deal with a somewhat different issue: does it make a difference to our understanding of organizational processes, when we take gender into account? I consider this question using a description of gendered processes in Swedish banks, based on a study of the work of employees in branch offices carried out between 1987 and 1989 (Acker & Ask, 1990; Acker, 1990).

2. The concept of gendered organizations

Concepts referring to social, economic, and symbolic differences between women and men have been developing and changing over the last 15–20 years (Acker, 1992b; Connell, 1987).

Today, among feminist scholars, gender refers not only to individuals and one-to-one relationships, but also to collective, organizational and historical processes (Connell, 1987) that differentiate between women and men and almost always accord to men more power than women (e.g. Scott, 1986). Organizations can be thought of as gendered (Acker, 1990, 1992a); organizational processes and practices reproduce the pervasive and persistent structuring along lines of gender that we see, for example, in Swedish banks.

To describe the ways that particular gender regimes emerge and are continuously renewed or changed, different points of entry to gendered processes can be identified.¹ A point of entry is a device, a way into the ongoing flow of actions and interactions that constitute organizational life. A first point of entry is through the ordinary, often daily, procedures and decisions that, while doing the work of the organization, also segregate, manage, control, and construct hierarchies in which gender, class and race are involved (Acker, 1992b). Sometimes decisions are consciously directed at maintaining gender or other divisions, but often such outcomes are unintended. For example, as Cockburn (1991) documents, a British retail chain decided to hire many more part-time workers to save on wages while still staffing its retail outlets adequately during peak hours of customer demand. Women, not men, were the available labour force, and this decision—taken on the basis of concern for the competitive strength of the company—increased the proportion of women in the lowest level of the organization.

In large bureaucratic organizations, gender assumptions are often embedded in rules, written procedures and policies which, in their implementation, contribute to gendered differences and inequalities. For example, as studies of comparable worth show, wage setting practices accord a negative value to the nurturing requirements of many women-dominated jobs, contributing to the low wages in such jobs, as compared with male-dominated jobs at similar levels of complexity (Acker, 1989).

A second point of entry is through the images, symbols, ideologies and forms of consciousness that portray and give legitimacy to gender inequalities and differences. Such images and forms of consciousness are part of organization culture, embedded in the symbolic processes that define the organization and give meaning to the efforts of both employees and management. These meanings may be contradictory and disputed.

¹This framework is summarized from several of my previous articles (Acker, 1990, 1992a, b).

A third point of entry is through face-to-face interactions, where people “do gender” (West & Zimmerman, 1987) as they do the ordinary work of the organization. Interactions are often loaded with gender implications that also subtly or obviously control and steer the participants (Kanter, 1977). Sexual harassment is an example, as is the sometimes barely observable deference that men often expect from women and that women frequently display toward men.

The fourth point of entry is through the making of the self as an adequate, and gendered, organizational performer. There are no single patterns of individual behaviour that are appropriate in all situations for women and men, but generally there are obvious and/or subtle gender differences. Failures in maintaining an appropriate gendered persona can lead to great difficulties in achieving success within organizations.

Underlying these processes is the gendered substructure of organizations, located in the practices relating to and assumptions about the extra-organizational reproduction of members (Acker, 1992a, b).² The daily and intergenerational physical and social reproduction of employees is carried out separately from the production of commodities, whether material objects or services. True, organizations socialize their own members; such socialization is implicit in the processes described above. But, participants do not spring fully grown and clothed from the head of the personnel department. They arrive at work from somewhere. In this sense, most organizations function on the assumption that the reproduction of their members will be done somewhere else and that this reproduction is not the responsibility of the organization. That responsibility is gender-divided, belonging for the most part to women. Assumptions about the gendered and extra-organizational nature of reproduction are incorporated in work schedules, task demands, hierarchies, work place locations, and the meaning of working for particular organizations, helping to perpetuate gender divisions outside organizations as well as within.

This understanding of the ongoing, processual nature of gendered organizations informs the following account of the gender regimes of Swedish banks. Gender regime is a convenient shorthand for the interlocking processes I have outlined above.

3. Method and sources of information

The research reported here was initiated to explore the relationships between gender, work organization, and the wage gap between women and men in Swedish banks. We studied the content and organization of work to assess whether an increasing gender wage gap could be associated with, or attributed to, a deskilling of work in retail branch banks. We found that work had not been deskilled, so that other explanations for the wage trend were needed. I have written about this elsewhere (Acker, 1991). The present paper only focuses on the content and organization of the work.

Our information comes from interviews, observations, and documents. We visited seven local offices with between 7 and 12 employees in commercial and savings banks in Stockholm, Uppsala, and Malmo. We interviewed 22 local bank employees in these offices, 4 men and 18 women, about work content, work organization, work experience, and wage

²Although the distinction between reproduction and production is an unsatisfactory way to express this idea, our language seems lacking in better terms. One of the difficulties with this distinction is that reproductive activities—such as making meals, caring for children, tending the sick and aged, even having babies—often take the form of commodities, produced in large organizations.

setting. In addition, we interviewed nine local and regional bank managers, one of whom was a woman, and 13 expert informants, five of whom were women, people who had special knowledge because of their staff positions in various banks or in the Swedish bank employees union (*Svenska bankmanna-forbundet*). We also carried out systematic observations in the local offices of customer flow and customer–employee and employee–employee interactions, to develop a picture of the rhythm and pace of work. Supplemental information was gathered from two staff development workshops on the work problems of cashiers, and from attendance at workshops and conferences on women's wages and equality problems held by the Swedish bank employees union.

The description below does not distinguish between different types of banks or different banking corporations for two reasons. First, we found the organization of work to be very similar, regardless of whether we were looking at a commercial or a savings bank. Second, the Swedish bank employees union organizes and bargains for all bank workers, of whom approximately 90% were union members. Central agreements covered wage setting and the union had the right to provide input on many management decisions, such as the introduction of new technology and the reorganization of work. This process contributed to commonalities across different banks.

4. The historical context of the gender regime in Swedish banks

Swedish banks, in common with those in many other countries, were male-dominated enclaves until after World War II. In the post-war period, as banking expanded, women were hired to fill the increasing numbers of positions, particularly lower level positions such as cashier or teller (*Strober & Arnold, 1987*).

Bank personnel, in Sweden as in Britain and the United States (*Crompton & Jones, 1984; Strober & Arnold, 1987*), were recruited as young people and learned the work on the job or in bank training courses. Management came from this group, through internal promotion. These career paths were open almost exclusively to men, who often expected banking to be a life-long occupation. The hierarchy was paternalistic and particularistic. At the top were the CEOs and a few others, next were the higher executives, followed by the “promoted” who were managers and technical staff, next were the “unpromoted”, a category that included tellers, other clerical workers, and lower-level service personnel, as well as guards and janitors. Finally, there was the category of “aspiranter”, or aspirers, in which most new employees were placed. As the title implies, these were people who aspire to join the bank. They spent two to three years in this position before their suitability for the work was finally decided. Promotion was a testament to individual worth and did not necessarily mean a change in tasks; even a teller could be promoted, but this was infrequent.

This hierarchy was sex segregated, and remains so despite some gains for women. By 1976 women already accounted for 54% of bank employees. By 1989, the year our study was completed, women occupied 60% of all jobs in Swedish banks. In that year, the very pinnacle of management was still exclusively male, but in high level managerial posts, women's share had increased from 1.9% in 1976 to 10.2% in 1989. At the intermediate level of managers and technical staff, women's representation had risen from 17.7% to 32.5%. Women's participation had also increased at the lower level of clerks, cashiers, and customer service personnel from 65.7% to 73.7%. Most women employees—80%—still

worked in jobs at that level in 1989. Thus, most women were still “unpromoted”, while only about 42% of men working in banks were at that low level (Acker & Ask, 1990).

Computerization, the development of automatic teller machines, direct deposit of wages, and a Bank Giro system for paying bills began to change the nature of bank work in the 1970s even more (Hedberg & Mattson, 1988; Mehlmann, 1988). However, computerization did not result in a decrease in the number of employees; contrary to the expectation of experts, employment increased (Svenska Bankmannaförbundet, 1989). Computerization did facilitate further change as Swedish banks were deregulated.

Deregulation, beginning in the late 1970s and coming to completion in 1985, lifted controls that had restricted foreign transactions, limited the size of loans, and regulated interest rates. Commercial banks moved aggressively into international markets and Swedish firms began to find sources of capital outside Sweden. Domestically, competition between banks increased as all banks began to actively solicit new customers with promises of high interest rates on deposits and easy loans. While retail banking activity increased, the supply of potential employees decreased. Particularly in the late 1980s, unemployment rates in large Swedish cities were between one and two percent, and banks reported difficulties in retaining the most desirable new employees, young and well-educated men. Proliferation of products and services in the late 1980s was a result of deregulation and of the competitive ethos of free market capitalism of the period. Another aspect of change was that in many cases local bank offices became profit centres, responsible for their own success, and the role of the branch manager changed accordingly, with new responsibilities for soliciting business and achieving a profitable operation.

In spite of all these changes, some aspects of the organization of banks were slow to change, and many elements in the old paternalistic structures remained. The hierarchy of bank employees was still, in 1989, described in terms of “*chef*,” “promoted,” “unpromoted,” and “aspirer,” reflecting the old career structure in which successful males moved in an orderly fashion through the ranks to leading positions. Local branch managers continued to be men. However, rapid expansion and new functions began to change recruitment patterns, as people with advanced technical and business training began to be hired from outside the organizations for higher-level jobs.

In sum, bank employment was feminized, but remained segregated; in 1989, 83% of women were in jobs that were more than 70% female. The traditional male dominated hierarchy of banking persisted in spite of some new management and specialist jobs being held by women.

5. The gender regime in local offices

Ordinary administrative practices, including processes of promotion, work assignment, work organization, and wage setting, contributed to a particular gender regime in local offices of Swedish banks. Tellers and customer service workers were usually women, managers were usually men. When first hired, inexperienced young men and women both received about the same salaries and the same work assignments. But managers’ decisions soon led to task differentiation. Even before employees moved from “aspirant” “status to being “unpromoted”, some men, according to our informants, began to get a mix of tasks that was somewhat different from that of the women. The differences in tasks then justified emerging differences in pay. Thus, in 1986, when the union and the bank employers organization agreed to attempt to achieve equal pay for the same work for men and

women, very few cases were found in which men and women were doing identical work in the same local office (Svenska Bankmannaförbundet, 1988). At that level, according to the banks' definitions of identical work, sex segregation of positions was almost complete.³

Young men with managerial potential were identified early, our informants said, and might be given special assignments to give them a broad view of banking as preparation for promotion. Only two of the women we interviewed had ever been offered promotion, although several had made one attempt to be considered, but had been discouraged from further tries by immediate rejection.

Many women, in contrast to men, worked part-time, and some banks created "housewife shifts" to provide extra help during peak hours. A particular woman might work full-time and then change to part-time when she had children, returning to full-time as the children got older. Her right to do this was guaranteed in Swedish law. Thus, both bank management and women employees had considerable flexibility. At the time of our study in the late 1980s, 42% of women bank workers in clerical, teller and customer service jobs in Sweden were working part-time. When women used the option of part-time work or used their legal right to parental leave, their promotion possibilities seemed to have been cut off. "A young woman coming to the bank wanting to make a career has got the same possibilities as the man, but then you have your first child and decide to stay home for a couple of years, then you're not interesting for the bank," said one of our informants. Other informants thought that women employees are not as visible to managers as are men employees, so that when decisions are to be made about promotions or wage raises, it is the men who are given consideration. Some men are not promoted, of course, but they tend to leave banking, while women tend to stay.

Images of the bank and understandings of what it means to be a bank employee helped to maintain this gendered structure. Most women employees we interviewed saw their bank as a service institution, there to help Swedish people. They felt deep loyalty to the bank and respect for its leaders, endowing them with characteristics of the wise and just father. Banking is honourable, and to work for a bank is a good thing to do. Everyone has an equally important contribution to make. This belief is facilitated in the local offices by the absence of formal job classifications among the customer service staff, and, in some offices, minimal awareness of status and responsibility differences. Tasks are assigned to individuals, not to job classifications. "We are all just bank service staff here," as one employee said in response to a question about her job or occupational title within the bank.

Language obscures difference and inequality. For example, the term for service staff is *tjansteman* in Swedish; it is a word with both class and gender implications. *Tjanst* refers to service; a *tjansteman* is an official (male) or an employee in an office. *Tjansteman* indicates status and sharply differentiates higher white-collar employees from workers. Worker, or "*arbetare*", is never used for white-collar or higher-level employees. Thus, to use the term "*tjansteman*" to refer to all bank employees is to obscure the structural similarities, as wage workers with relatively little power on the job, between the lower white-collar jobs and workers' jobs, as well as to obscure the differences between women's and men's work in banks.

³This is the kind of sex segregation that would not appear in a statistical study. These employees would all be in the large category of teller or customer service worker, although the banks themselves do not use these designations as job classifications.

One consequence of this comprehension of banking, as service provided by substantially equal staff working for a benign and wise father, was that certain, possibly controversial, things could not be discussed. Talking about wages was the most obvious taboo. Bank employees, managers and expert informants all agreed that you simply do not discuss with others what sort of salary increase you have had or the level of your present salary. What you earn is an intimate fact. To ask someone else about her salary level was unthinkable. Wages were individually set (Acker, 1990) and thus reflected the evaluation of the individual by managers. To compare wages would be to compare the essential worth of individuals, opening up the possibility of humiliation, but also opening the way to questioning the fairness of the bank, the good father.

Interactions on the job and the self-creation of the persona of a bank service employee both have a gendered subtext. The direct service person is the public face of the bank; management teaches this lesson. Much of the work of the local office is done in full view of the public. Therefore, we were told, it is necessary that employees work together as an amicable team. The good employee must have the knowledge to carry out technical functions accurately and quickly, but also must be calm, positive, happy, unstressed, friendly, smiling, and caring. Although these characteristics are expected of both men and women, they are, of course, stereotypically feminine.

Behind the amicable team lie other gendered realities. Men compete for advancement and actively plan careers, as both men and women we interviewed told us. Most of the women employees we interviewed do not compete or plan careers because they have learned that it is futile and best not to try. At the same time our informants thought that women did not push themselves forward enough. They do a good job, are careful and efficient, expecting to be appropriately rewarded. Men, on the other hand, go to the manager and ask for new tasks or higher pay. Men were seen by some of our women informants as risk-takers who talk as though they know something when they really do not. At the same time, women employees see themselves as more suited to service work in the bank than men. As one woman said, “Men don’t think about human beings, only about numbers and money.”

The gendered substructure of Swedish bank organization consisted in the ways that banks constructed the articulation between paid employment and home and family responsibilities. There was one pattern for men and another for women. Men were expected to work full-time and to make a career; women were assumed to put family first and to remain at the bottom at work. Men’s careers were encouraged and rewarded. Women’s different pattern was facilitated by the offer of part-time work and easy return to work after periods at home. Among the women employees whom we interviewed, almost half were working part-time, but had previously worked full-time. Some full-time employees had previously worked part-time. Welfare state programs, such as parental leave, and legal rights to return to the job or to work part-time, supported these gendered arrangements, as well as the ongoing gendered divisions of paid and unpaid labour.

In sum, the gender regime in local bank offices was created through work assignment and organization and promotion practices. These practices, differentiating between women and men, were supported by images of the bank as wise father, whose wishes were implemented by women who serve the customer, while young men were seen as potentially joining the wise father in decision making. Interactions in the local offices, as reported by those we interviewed, reinforced these images. The women worked to create themselves as good, caring women—competent, efficient, careful, and dedicated, but not pushy and

ambitious, characteristics they saw as typical of men. Different treatment of women and men at significant decision points, along with different expectations and welfare state supports for different career lines, created a permanent pool of trained women employees who would not seek promotion and who would stay at relatively low wages (see also Baude, 1992). This aspect of the gender regime, the existence of a large group of permanently “unpromoted”, undoubtedly helped banks to keep their wage costs down and to avoid disruptive competition among employees for more desirable “promoted” positions.

6. A changing gender regime?

This well-established gender regime in Swedish banks seemed to be in the process of change at the time of our study. In the mid to late 1980s, in response to new opportunities created by deregulation (Hedberg & Mattson, 1988; Mehlmann, 1988), a significant reorganization of work was attempted in many branch offices of Swedish banks to reallocate tasks and to transform the bank teller, previously the largest category of lower white-collar work, into a generalized customer service employee (*allexpeditör*) who could handle all of the tasks in the local branch office, with the exception of a few management functions. Our informants expected that the teller job would disappear, and union officials thought that the status of the redefined job would rise. In most banks, the number of tellers was being reduced. This innovation depended for its success on the knowledge and skills of these employees, who had long experience serving the public in local branch offices. Because women were the vast majority in these positions, the new work demands affected many more women than men.

In our interviews, bank employees identified the many changes they experienced in their work and the additional responsibilities of their jobs. First, new products and services were constantly being developed. One bank manager said that his bank had between 150 and 200 different products and services at the time of the interview. While all of these were not directed at the customers of the local office, many were. All bank employees, including tellers, needed to know about the products and services if they were to respond to customer demands. In addition, with the proliferation of products and services, employees, including tellers, were increasingly expected to promote and sell as well as to give the usual service.

Advice-giving was one of the new services offered by banks to ordinary customers. Advising ranged from relatively simple matters such as which type of account is most profitable for a particular customer to more complex issues such as stock and insurance purchases, real estate transactions, and tax planning. Another major change was the addition of loan processing and approval to the work of the transformed teller, the “*allexpeditör*.” In most of the offices we visited, such “unpromoted” employees had the authority to approve loans up to 50,000 Swedish kronor (at the time, about US\$9000.00). Above that amount, they could investigate a request and recommend a decision, but this had to be approved by the manager or, in some cases, assistant manager.

Another change was the institution in 1988 of new charges for bank services in the local offices. Local employees were responsible for explaining these new charges and convincing the customers that they were necessary and fair. They were also supposed to steer customers’ behaviour, not only getting them to accept new fees for previously free services, but also encouraging them to use the bankomat and the giro system, to get customers out of the bank offices, and to discourage unwanted visits, primarily from old people who

sometimes used the neighbourhood bank as a place for a chat. In addition, employees were to actively seek customers, rather than waiting for them to appear, taking part in telephone or letter campaigns to attract customers for particular services. Bank employees felt that, in general, their employers expected them to relate differently to customers than they had in the past. They felt that they were now expected to be more aggressive, more profit-oriented, more manipulative, and less caring and supportive. This constituted, for both branch managers and customer service employees, a shift away from the old gender images of the bank and of their own work.

The old routine tasks remained—handling deposits and withdrawals, cashing checks, taking care of the cash machines, taking orders for checks and credit cards, opening and closing accounts, managing safe deposit boxes, handling foreign exchange. In addition, there were still internal tasks, including paperwork, much of which was not eliminated with computerization. Moreover, some previously centralized clerical functions had been decentralized to the local offices. “A flood of paper” is the way that many described it. Lists had to be checked daily for errors and their accuracy confirmed. In addition, customer questions and complaints led to investigations into the paper records. Everyday there was the post to be opened, sorted, and dealt with and the telephone to be answered.

In the ideal reorganized office there would be a rotation of responsibilities and tasks so that no one person would be stuck with routine teller work, which was seen as low status and confining, or with clerical tasks, which were seen as uninteresting. In addition, a staff of these new and skilled generalists would work as a team and absences would be easily covered because everyone would know how to do everything.

We found that although this type of organization was the goal in most of the local offices we visited, in only one had it been substantially achieved. The gender structure of the work force and the economic structure of the community served by the local office were major differences between the one office in which the reorganization had succeeded and one in which it was given lip service but was little in evidence. Other offices were in between, handling certain functions with specialization, but others on a rotating basis. These differences produced three different gender regimes.

The first was the “*allexpedition*” bank. The only bank that had fully implemented the new ideas was a small office with a manager, an assistant manager,⁴ and five customer service employees (*allexpeditorer*), all women except the manager. All were seasoned bank employees; the youngest and least experienced had worked in banking for 17 years. The bank served a residential community with one large corporate customer and a few smaller business customers. The employees had spent a year discussing and redesigning their office and work routines before the new organization was begun.

The physical design of the office facilitated the work patterns described below. The office was essentially a large, light, square room divided diagonally by a low counter with two teller stations at one end. Behind the counter was a large open space with desks along the back wall. The assistant manager, a woman, sat at one of these desks. The manager’s office was behind this area, separated from it by a large window. Thus, the whole space was visible to customers and managers and there was much room for walking about.

⁴The Swedish word for assistant manager, *andra man*, reflects the old masculine status structure. *Andra man* means second man or second-in-charge. This person was a man and was not an assistant, but someone with an independent status. Although many second men are now women, this position still has responsibilities different from those of manager.

Four groups of routine and less desirable tasks circulated among the *allexpeditorer* on a weekly basis, each woman did teller work every four to six weeks. The tasks in each weekly bundle had been decided upon by the employees, so that they could have variety and the chance to develop their knowledge and skills. In addition to the weekly tasks, these women functioned as a team, responding to customer requests as they occurred and providing loan assistance, advice, information, and other services such as purchase of stock funds and other securities. When a customer walked into the office needing something more than routine teller service, whoever was free provided it. The goal was that one *allexpeditorer* should meet all of a customer's needs. The employees also shared telephone responsibility. When the telephone rang, whoever was free at that moment answered and carried through the request to its conclusion. The assistant manager and the manager did not rotate tasks, but they "hopped in", as they put it, if everyone else was busy, to serve a customer or answer the telephone. The manager and assistant manager did trouble-shooting, advising, and generally anything that needed doing.

The key characteristics of this organization were shared responsibility and flexibility. Different people stepped in to take up tasks as they presented themselves, while also carrying out the ongoing routine functions. This organization meant that the individual had to pay attention to several things simultaneously, concentrating on a technical problem while keeping an eye on who was coming in the door, answering the telephone, and giving a bit of advice to a colleague. The work required a high degree of cooperation and sensitive awareness of the ongoing flow of activity, who was busy with what, and what in the common arena of requests and demands most urgently needed attending to at any moment. There was no formal supervision. However, since no employee knew everything and new problems constantly arose, there was a need to confer and ask advice. This they did with and for each other. Each employee had to make decisions about who to ask on the basis of knowledge of the others' expertise and whether or not the other was too busy to be interrupted. If the problem was particularly difficult or the information needed particularly specialized, the employee might confer with the manager, the assistant manager, or telephone a specialist in the head office.

The team process functioned so well that the employees did not see themselves as having a leader, but only that the manager and assistant manager had somewhat different tasks. But, as the assistant manager put it, "The customers always want to have someone who decides, or someone to complain to, and that is the leadership function. Otherwise, perhaps we really wouldn't need it, we function today so much like a team." In fact, the manager did have some functions that put him in the role of the responsible, and fatherly, male. He had a yearly discussion with each employee about her progress and future plans, and he did the non-routine work with wealthy customers and the big corporate client. He was also responsible for the over-all profitability of the branch office.

Employees in this bank were satisfied and challenged by the changes in banking. The amount of knowledge they needed to do their jobs had increased dramatically, as had areas of independent decision making and responsibility. All of this made the jobs more interesting. However, the changes also brought new stress. Lack of time to study and read, to keep up with new information and knowledge was one problem. All these women had taken many courses in the banks' internal education system, and some of them were spending their evenings reading business journals and texts, but they sometimes still felt inadequate to the task. Another source of stress was the attempt to juggle several tasks at one time. "Sometimes I feel split apart," one employee told us. She and others also felt the

heavy responsibility of approving loans. This was a responsibility to the customer and to the bank. Several felt that, following bank policy, they had approved loans to customers who would have difficulty making repayment, and this disturbed them. Finally, they were all keenly aware that their increased knowledge and responsibility had not brought them higher wages, and all felt that they were underpaid.

Although the gender hierarchy in this office was attenuated by collaborative work, the women thought about their work in gendered terms, defining their abilities in contrast to the inabilities of men. “Men are not fit for this kind of job, they’re fumbling. They don’t have a sense of order and accuracy.” Or, “Men can’t stand the stress. They can’t do a lot of different things at the same time.” In their view, the *allexpedition* bank was a woman’s place, dependent upon the natural abilities of women for its success.

The second form of organization I call the *specialized function plus “allexpedition” bank*. Several banks fell into this category, combining the new generalist “*allexpeditorer*” with some specialists, either full-time tellers or more expert specialists such as financial advisors and lawyers. In some cases, the full-time tellers were older women with many years of experience, in others they were young aspirants who were learning banking and studying with the expectation that they too would become *allexpeditorer*. The lack of sufficient experienced staff was one reason that these bank offices had not fully transformed their organization. In these offices there was job rotation among those who were generalists, “*allexpeditorer*”. Employees frequently conferred with each other, turning first to work comrades for help or confirmation when dealing with new problems. These employees valued their team work and their close cooperative relations with other employees. However, there was not the intense team work nor the continual alertness to the encompassing task milieu we found in the *allexpedition* bank. In addition, management views varied on the degree to which the new functions of the bank should be carried out by generalists with broad knowledge or specialists with in-depth knowledge (Hedberg & Mattson, 1988).

In these offices, most of the employees were women with the exception of the manager and one or two young men who were aspirants. The assistant managers were women, responsible for the daily running of the office and for personnel matters. Sometimes the female assistant managers were referred to as “office mothers,” and were seen as the nurturing figure that holds daily life together. They may be “unpromoted” even though they have considerable responsibility. The male manager plays a paternal role, dealing with business in the outside world, seeing that the total enterprise survives within its environment. Often absent on business, the manager may also be seen as remote and inaccessible.

The physical layouts of these bank offices facilitated managerial distance and worked against the intense collaboration of the fully transformed office. The tellers’ cages were more closed off, there was less open space behind the counters, and more individual offices that were not visible from the open public workspace. The manager and assistant manager could not jump in when needed, even had they wanted to do so, because the flow of work was not immediately visible to them. Employees could not easily move from checking yesterday’s printouts to serving a customer, because the clerical work was located in a separate office, not in the common space.

At the same time, these employees were happy with the changes in banking. With all the new tasks, work was never boring. However, they too experienced difficulties in keeping up with the flow of new information and felt time pressures from the added responsibilities

and demands of customers. They felt stress from what they perceived as contradictory demands—to give good service to customers and to always contribute to the profitability of the bank. In some areas customers may be old, poor, immigrants, or “social welfare cases,” as one put it. These may be the very ones who need extra help and financial counselling, but they are not profitable customers. Long queues and pressures for productivity also worked against service goals. For example, employees were often expected to look over customers’ accounts when providing routine services to see if the customer’s funds were placed in the most advantageous way. Time pressures often made this impossible, leaving the employee frustrated in her desire to do the best possible job.

The *specialized function bank* had changed the least in response to the new ideas about work organization and the tasks of local bank employees. It was located in the business section of a large city and had a high number of business clients. The business opportunities available to this urban branch bank were probably a factor in the continued specialization in this local office. This bank was divided into two sections, one for private customers and one for business customers. Those working with business customers were specialized, one—the bank manager—handling large businesses, one handling smaller businesses, and a third dealing with the building industry. On the private customer side, there were two cashiers (one part-time), one specialist in foreign exchange matters, one specialist in securities and funds, two who specialized in taxation and financial advising. Only one person, a woman, had the “*allexpedition*” function, including advising, taxes, funds, stocks, loan processing, and covering the cashier’s desk at lunch.

The fairly traditional task structure of the specialized function bank was reflected in the physical organization of the office. In contrast to the lightness and openness of the other local offices we visited, this office was long, dark, and narrow, with a high counter separating private customers from employees. At the side were some private cubicles for consultation with customers. Two teller cages were at the back end of the counter. Behind the counter was a rather narrow space with desks preventing much free movement. At the rear, with often-closed doors, were the private offices of the manager and those dealing with business customers.

In further contrast to the other offices, here all loans had to be approved by the manager or the assistant manager. Organization was hierarchical and there was no job rotation, and, apparently, no ambition to move toward that form of organization. However, most of the employees were experienced, and when needed they substituted for each other. Customers’ initial requests seemed to be taken by whoever was available and then referred to the appropriate specialist.

In the specialized office seven employees were men and five were women. A traditional gender structure was an integral part of the traditional bureaucratic structure. Of the women, two were cashiers, one was a secretary, one a private customer specialist and one an “*allexpeditor*.”

As in the other offices, the assistant manager, here a man, ran the daily, private customer business, while the manager supervised the work of those, all men, who dealt with business customers. A clear status structure existed. Business customers were more important than private customers. Among the private customer staff there was considerable competition, some antagonism toward management, and some bitterness over thwarted ambitions for promotion. Some of these specialists were formally “promoted,” but they were still stuck in a local branch office. The oldest employee, and the one with the longest experience in banking, was a woman teller. She told us that she was very satisfied with the work and had

no ambitions to do anything else. The manager informed us that she had been “promoted” because of her skill and long service. In terms of status in the formal hierarchy she thus had a higher standing than most other tellers. This was the only office in our study in which the old-fashioned teller was retained as an intentional and desired part of the organization.

The tellers and the *allexpeditor* reported that work had changed a great deal over the years, and that customers had become much more demanding. However, only the tellers reported greater stress. The others explicitly denied any difficulties or any increased stress.

7. Discussion

The gender regimes of local bank offices had many similarities, but also substantial differences. In all the offices in this study, women—with the exception of a few recently hired young men—were those in the lowest level positions, in spite of their high levels of experience. These regimes were maintained by a combination of managerial practices that actively limited promotion possibilities, by images of the bank as the wise father, represented by the kindly manager assisted by dedicated women, and by expectations on the part of bank managers about women’s work and family responsibilities which seemed to be confirmed by the ways in which women used welfare state supports for parenthood. These regimes differed in gender composition and degree of hierarchy; the office with only women employees had a flat structure and a high degree of task sharing, while the office with the most men had a hierarchical structure and a high degree of specialization.

Plans to increase the functions and responsibilities of the bank teller job were based on the existing gender structure, including the large pool of experienced women bank workers. Success in implementing this new organization varied with the existing gender regime of the branch office. Broad and shared skills, task rotation, and a highly collaborative work process were developed in the all-female office. These women were among the permanently unpromoted, and were not therefore competing with each other for promotion, pay, or status. The lack of competitiveness probably facilitated their cooperation (see also [Kvande and Rasmussen, 1994](#)). In contrast, in the male-predominant hierarchical office specialization and competition prevailed. The innovative job structure and work organization had not been implemented, perhaps because it would have required a reduction of hierarchy and differentiation, and a loss of status for the male employees.

Although hierarchy was dramatically reduced in the work group in one office, higher levels of knowledge, skill and responsibility that were demanded in the lower-level and female-predominant positions did not alter the overall gender regimes of Swedish banks. These women employees and their jobs had been defined as relatively unskilled and as belonging to the bottom of bank hierarchies; management did not change that stereotypical image, at least as far as wage levels were concerned; these remained the same.

At the same time, increasing competition between banks and demands for efficiency and profit were undermining the images and some of the practices of the old gender regime. The paternalistic service ethic of the local branches was contradicted by the new emphasis on profit and competition. Adding to the contradictions, the forced resignation in 1989 of the head of the leading Swedish bank because of financial indiscretions, shook the pride and loyalty of bank employees. The paternalist image of the banks and their leaders as wise and just and careful of the people’s money was being replaced by a new masculine image of the aggressive, profit-hungry and not-always-honest entrepreneur.

8. Conclusion

Does consideration of gender make a difference to organizational analysis? I have tried to show that in the case of local branches of Swedish banks, it does. Starting from the assumption that gender is embedded in the ordinary processes of running organizations, my strategy was to use various points of entry into those processes to make gender visible. The processes themselves constitute an ongoing flow of activities, often changing as new conditions arise and new policies are attempted, and always informed and legitimized by gendered images of the organization and its participants. Gendered differences within these processes are integral to gender differences in life outside the organization, in the reproduction of organizational participants. The term “gender regime” stands for the ways that gender is part of organizational processes at a particular time, in a particular organization. In Swedish banks the gender regime constituted a two-tiered and gendered work force, allowing the banks to take advantage of new opportunities by upgrading the bank teller job, without increasing wage costs. However, the existing gender regimes of local banks shaped the possibilities for change and limited the success of the reorganization.

Afterword: Since I finished this research, a crisis in Swedish banking has occurred, resulting in government assistance to avoid bankruptcy. The very executives who were responsible for the crisis left banking with huge “golden parachutes”. The public was indignant and gender images of banks as the wise, paternal conservators of the people’s money were badly damaged. The crisis led to cuts in staff as well as other changes. A study done today might find fewer attempts at work organization innovation or altered gender regimes in local offices.

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